A+MENTOR

Indian History & Geography

Competitive-exam starter notes | UPSC • State PCS • JKSSB

How to use these notes

Read the key points, recall the facts without looking, and attempt the practice questions at the end. These are starter notes, not a substitute for the complete syllabus.

1. Sources and Periods

• History is studied through archaeological evidence, inscriptions, coins, manuscripts, monuments and literary sources. Each source has limitations and should be cross-checked.

• Prehistory refers to periods before written records; protohistory is used for cultures whose script is not fully deciphered or whose records are limited; history is supported by decipherable written evidence.

• Broad ancient Indian chronology: Palaeolithic, Mesolithic, Neolithic, Chalcolithic, Harappan civilisation, Vedic period, mahajanapadas, Mauryan and post-Mauryan states, Gupta period and regional kingdoms. Dates are approximate and can vary by scholarly interpretation.

2. Harappan / Indus Valley Civilisation

• Major sites include Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Rakhigarhi, Kalibangan and Lothal. The civilisation is known for planned settlements, drainage, craft production, seals, weights and long-distance trade.

• Dholavira is noted for its water-management structures; Lothal is often associated with a dockyard-like structure, though interpretations of the feature have been debated.

• The Harappan script remains undeciphered. Avoid treating every seal or symbol as having a certain translation.

• Urban decline was likely multi-causal, involving changing river systems, climate shifts, changing trade and settlement patterns rather than one universally accepted cause.

3. Vedic Period and Mahajanapadas

• The Rigveda is the oldest Veda. Early Vedic society is often associated with pastoral life and tribal polities; later Vedic texts show greater importance of agriculture, settled kingdoms and social stratification.

• Sixteen mahajanapadas are described in Buddhist and Jain traditions. Magadha rose in prominence due to fertile land, access to resources, elephants, river routes and capable rulers.

• Buddhism is associated with Siddhartha Gautama; Jainism with Vardhamana Mahavira as the 24th Tirthankara. Both traditions questioned aspects of Vedic ritual authority and developed influential monastic traditions.

4. Mauryan and Gupta Periods

• Chandragupta Maurya established the Mauryan Empire; Ashoka's inscriptions are major sources for his reign and his policy of dhamma after the Kalinga war.

• The Arthashastra is traditionally associated with Kautilya/Chanakya, but its composition and layers are debated by scholars.

• The Gupta period saw developments in Sanskrit literature, mathematics, astronomy, art and temple architecture. It should not be described as a uniformly prosperous 'golden age' for every group or region.

5. Medieval India: Quick Framework

• Early medieval India included many regional powers, agrarian expansion, temple-centred economies and changing land grants. Avoid treating the period as politically uniform.

• The Delhi Sultanate comprised several dynasties, including the Mamluk, Khalji, Tughlaq, Sayyid and Lodi dynasties.

• The Mughal Empire was founded by Babur after the First Battle of Panipat (1526). Akbar developed a broad imperial system; later Mughal authority weakened amid regional state formation and other pressures.

6. Modern India and National Movement

• The arrival of European trading companies preceded the growth of colonial territorial rule. The Battle of Plassey (1757) and Battle of Buxar (1764) were important in the expansion of Company power in Bengal.

• The Revolt of 1857 had diverse causes and participants; it is described in different ways in historiography. The Crown assumed direct rule in 1858 after Company rule ended.

• The Indian National Congress was founded in 1885. Major milestones include the Swadeshi movement (after Bengal's 1905 partition), Non-Cooperation (1920–22), Civil Disobedience (including the Salt March, 1930), Quit India (1942) and independence in 1947.

• Constitutional developments to revise include the Indian Councils Acts, Government of India Acts of 1919 and 1935, and the Indian Independence Act, 1947.

7. Geography Basics

• Latitude measures angular distance north or south of the Equator; longitude measures angular distance east or west of the Prime Meridian.

• India's Standard Meridian is 82°30′ E. Indian Standard Time is UTC+5:30. The Tropic of Cancer crosses eight Indian states.

• Physiographic divisions commonly include the Himalayas, Northern Plains, Peninsular Plateau, Indian Desert, Coastal Plains and Islands.

• Monsoon rainfall is shaped by seasonal wind reversal, relief, land-sea heating contrasts and regional weather systems. The Western Ghats produce strong orographic rainfall on their windward side.

• Major soil groups include alluvial, black, red and yellow, laterite, arid and forest/mountain soils. Soil distribution varies with parent material, climate, relief and drainage.

• Rivers are commonly grouped into Himalayan and Peninsular systems. Compare their sources, flow regimes, basins, tributaries and drainage patterns.

8. Environment and Map Practice

• Revise biosphere reserves, national parks, wildlife sanctuaries, wetlands and Ramsar sites from current official lists because designations can change.

• Map practice: locate major mountain ranges, passes, rivers, dams, mineral belts, ports, neighbouring countries and important Indian cities.

• For competitive exams, distinguish weather (short-term atmospheric conditions) from climate (long-term patterns), and renewable from non-renewable resources.

Practice Questions

1. Which Harappan site is particularly noted for sophisticated water-management structures?

A. Dholavira

B. Sarnath

C. Taxila

D. Pataliputra

Answer: A — Dholavira
Explanation: Dholavira is well known for reservoirs and water-management features.

2. The Rigveda belongs to which broad historical tradition?

A. Vedic

B. Mauryan

C. Gupta

D. Mughal

Answer: A — Vedic
Explanation: The Rigveda is the oldest Veda and a key source for early Vedic history.

3. Ashoka's inscriptions are important because they provide evidence about:

A. Only Mughal administration

B. Mauryan policies and proclamations

C. The 1857 revolt

D. The Harappan script

Answer: B — Mauryan policies and proclamations
Explanation: Inscriptions are primary evidence for Ashoka's proclamations and dhamma.

4. The First Battle of Panipat (1526) is associated with the foundation of which empire in India?

A. Mauryan

B. Gupta

C. Mughal

D. Chola

Answer: C — Mughal
Explanation: Babur defeated Ibrahim Lodi in 1526.

5. India's Standard Meridian is:

A. 68°7′ E

B. 82°30′ E

C. 90° E

D. 23°30′ N

Answer: B — 82°30′ E
Explanation: 82°30′ E is used to define Indian Standard Time.

6. Which latitude passes through the middle part of India?

A. Equator

B. Arctic Circle

C. Tropic of Cancer

D. Antarctic Circle

Answer: C — Tropic of Cancer
Explanation: The Tropic of Cancer crosses India.

7. A rain-shadow region is generally found:

A. Only at the Equator

B. On the leeward side of a mountain barrier

C. At every river mouth

D. Only in polar regions

Answer: B — On the leeward side of a mountain barrier
Explanation: Air loses moisture on the windward side, leaving relatively drier conditions downwind.

8. Which is a major source used to study ancient Indian history?

A. Only social media posts

B. Inscriptions

C. Modern weather forecasts

D. Telephone directories

Answer: B — Inscriptions
Explanation: Inscriptions provide evidence about rulers, donations, events and languages.

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